

CATASTROPHE • 2006

Cyclone Larry

The morning the Wet Tropics went quiet — and Australia ran out of bananas.

Innisfail, Far North Queensland • 2006

■ FAST FACTS

0

DIRECT FATALITIES

10,
000
+

HOMES DAMAGED

\$1.
5bn

DAMAGE (2006)

Cat
5

SEVERE CYCLONE

240
+

PEAK GUSTS KM/H

80
%

AUS. BANANA CROP LOST

TIMELINE

17 Mar 2006

Tropical disturbance develops in the Coral Sea.

19 Mar, Afternoon

Larry rapidly intensifies to Category 5.

20 Mar, 6:28 AM

Eye crosses coast south of Innisfail.

20 Mar, Afternoon

Weakens rapidly over Atherton Tablelands.

Dawn broke slowly over the Wet Tropics on 20 March 2006 — or rather, it didn't. By the time first light should have filtered through the ancient rainforest canopy above Innisfail, the sky had already turned a sickly green-grey. Cyclone Larry had been tracking west for three days through the Coral Sea, tightening its spiral with each passing hour until it had become one of the most intense tropical cyclones to approach the Australian mainland in a generation. By 6:28 in the morning, Far North Queensland's banana belt was about to be erased.

The residents of the Innisfail district had been warned. In the 48 hours prior, the Bureau of Meteorology issued escalating warnings. Schools closed, shelves emptied, and Innisfail's daily life fell into an anxious quiet. Families moved vehicles to high ground, strapped roofing iron, and gathered in hallways and bathrooms with mattresses against the louvres.

“The bananas were just gone. The cane was gone. Fifty years of farming, obliterated before breakfast. But we were still standing — and that was all that mattered.”

— Innisfail farmer, March 2006

A Miraculous Zero

Among the most remarkable aspects of Cyclone Larry's history is what did not happen. Despite the ferocity of the storm — winds that snapped power poles like matchsticks — there were no direct fatalities. The zero death toll stands as an extraordinary testament to the effectiveness of Australia's emergency management systems.



The Banana Belt — Every plant across thousands of hectares was snapped at the stem. Australia's banana industry took nearly two years to recover.

The Banana Belt Broken

The agricultural catastrophe was the defining legacy of Larry's passage. The Wet Tropics region produces the overwhelming majority of Australia's banana crop, and the cyclone eliminated nearly all of it in a single morning. Banana prices surged to over \$6/kg. Total economic damage was estimated at A\$1.5 billion.

Innisfail and the Recovery

Innisfail's Art Deco buildings — erected after a devastating 1918 cyclone — bore the full brunt. Yet the town's response was immediate. Within hours, the community had begun clearing roads and checking on neighbours. Thousands of ADF personnel and emergency volunteers converged. The federal government committed over \$150 million in immediate disaster relief.

THE AFTERMATH



Left: A resident surveys roof damage. Right: BOM photo of leaning power poles, Innisfail.